

Push to drill off state’s coastline

Trump may want to open federal waters, but oil firms may balk at California’s rules.

By HAYLEY SMITH

The Trump administration reportedly has plans to open the waters off California’s coast to new oil and gas drilling for the first time in four decades, drawing swift condemnation from Gov. Gavin Newsom, lawmakers and environmental groups that say it would be disastrous for the state’s environment, economy and clean energy targets.

Whether energy companies would be interested in such leases is another question. Experts say the resources are limited and oil majors may not clamor for leases that could ensnare them in the Golden State’s stringent environmental policies.

Trump has focused heavily on increasing fossil fuel production in the United States, yet some say offering the opportunity to drill in the Pacific is more likely a political move from an administration that has repeatedly targeted California’s green ambitions.

Details of the administration’s plan are still emerging, but maps from the Bureau of Ocean Energy identify four West Coast planning areas, three off the coast of California and one off Oregon and Washington. The administration is planning to propose up to six offshore lease sales off California between 2027 and 2030, according to internal documents first reported by the Washington Post.

Officials with the U.S. Interior Department declined to comment, citing the federal government shutdown. Last month, the administration also announced plans to open the entire 1.5-million-acre coastal plain of Alaska’s Arctic National Wildlife Refuge to oil and gas leasing, which Interior Secretary Doug Burgum said would create jobs and strengthen U.S. energy independence.

California has about two dozen operating oil platforms in state and federal waters, some of which are visible from the shore in different parts of Southern California. But new leases have not been granted in federal waters since 1984, in part due to strong opposition stemming from a 1969 oil spill off [See **Drilling**, A7]



FREDERIC J. BROWN AFP/Getty Images

AT YOSEMITE and some other national parks, public-facing services continued amid the federal shutdown.

A facade at national parks?

As the government shutdown stretched on last week, Travis Puglisi saw something unusual at Joshua Tree National Park: two rangers doing graffiti checks.

“Do you know how often I run into rangers in the park and actually have conversations with them out in the field?” he said. “Never.”

Puglisi would know what’s normal. As a hiking guide, he logs about 700 miles on foot in the park each year.

“The park is in many ways better staffed and taken care of now than it is during normal operations,” he said. “It’s really

Camps and bathrooms stayed open, but behind the scenes, conservation and research services ended during shutdown

By LILA SEIDMAN AND ALEX WIGGLESWORTH

weird.”

The longest government shutdown in U.S. history appears poised to end. But at certain national parks, it hasn’t been obvious one was happening.

That’s in stark contrast to the last shutdown during President Trump’s first term, when images of overflowing dumpsters and bathrooms made headlines.

Another visible difference this time is that some visitor centers — often the first stop on a tourist’s itinerary — remained open. That includes those at [See **Parks**, A8]

Fire crews’ Palisades concerns hidden

LAFD knew of complaints about Lachman blaze mop-up but said nothing, as victims for months questioned how the inferno started

By PAUL PRINGLE AND ALENE TCHEKMEDYIAN

For months, as victims pleaded for information, the Los Angeles Fire Department kept secret that its firefighters were ordered to stop mop-up operations on a small brush fire that continued to smolder and reignited days later into the massive Palisades fire.

At least one department official learned that a battalion chief had directed the firefighters to pack up their hoses and leave the scene of the Lachman fire Jan. 2, even though they complained that the ground was still smoking in places and rocks remained hot to the touch, according to a source who was briefed on the matter in June.



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

“WE WON’T leave a fire that has any hot spots,” then-Chief Kristin Crowley said on Jan. 16.

But the department did not include that finding, or any detailed examination of the reignition, in its after-action report on the Jan. 7 Palisades fire — or otherwise make the information public — despite victims demanding answers for months about how the blaze started and whether more could have been done to prevent it.

The report, which was released last month and intended to identify shortcomings in the LAFD’s preparedness and response, only briefly mentioned the prior blaze, even though its role in starting the Palisades fire was clear to firefighters. According to the report, on the morning of Jan. 7, an LAFD captain called Fire Station 23 — one of two stations in Pacific Palisades — to say that the [See **LAFD**, A9]



NOAH BERGER Associated Press

UC BERKELEY CRITICIZED

The FBI will investigate the university after clashes and arrests during protests outside a conservative group’s event. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

John Williams honored at Bowl

L.A. Philharmonic names the venue’s stage after the blockbuster film composer. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Mostly cloudy. L.A. Basin: 73/56. **B5**

Markets **A13**
Opinion Voices **A14**

AEG could add to L.A. Live

A new high-rise would have a hotel, residences, bar and restaurants. **BUSINESS, A11**

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IOC nears a decision on transgender athletes

Rules for those assigned male at birth come amid recent political discussion.

By STEVE HENSON

The International Olympic Committee appears to be near a pivotal decision with wide-ranging consequences in advance of the 2028 Los Angeles Summer Olympics: Should athletes assigned male at birth be allowed to compete in women’s events?

The debate comes amid a larger societal discussion about transgender athletes that has taken center stage in recent years, fueled in part by President Trump and others who are putting pressure on the IOC for a ban. The decision is being closely watched in California, where officials have tried to establish some protections for transgender athletes and pushed back against Trump.

Olympic officials are in a familiar position: trying to balance fairness in competition with inclusion. Bradley Anawalt, an endocrinologist and professor at the University of Washington, says those values conflict when it comes to transgender athletes.

“This is a topic that requires nuanced thinking and discussion,” Anawalt said.

There were reports this week that the Olympic committee was ready to ban transgender women in female competition. The IOC insisted that was premature but did not refute that a new policy was forthcoming.

A spokesperson confirmed that medical and scientific director Dr. Jane Thornton updated IOC members last week at a meeting in Lausanne, Switzerland. [See **Transgender**, A13]

California could be hit with days of heavy rain

By RONG-GONG LIN II AND SUMMER LIN

A fast-moving atmospheric river is heading toward California this week and could pack a punch, threatening periods of heavy rain and possible flooding and debris flows in recently burned areas.

After arriving in Northern California on Wednesday, the storm system is expected to land in Southern

California on Thursday, where it could remain all the way through Saturday. It could produce the most rain downtown Los Angeles has seen in at least a month, and possibly since February.

“There is a chance for burn area flash flooding and debris flow issues. A flood watch will be possible for burn scars,” Rose Schoenfeld, a National Weather Service meteorologist in Oxnard, said Tuesday afternoon.

Although the storm brings some concerns about flooding, it could also mark the end of the autumn fire season. Rainstorms in Northern California have already lessened the seasonal fire danger there considerably, and this storm could do likewise in the Southland.

The National Weather Service office in Oxnard called the forecast storm “potentially significant,” with roadway flooding expected in spots, rockslides

possible on canyon roads and a chance of mudflows.

The storm could snarl traffic in Los Angeles and Ventura counties for the Thursday afternoon and Friday commutes, causing water to pool on roadways. The L.A. metro area could be hard hit, with localized freeway flooding in low spots, forecasters warned.

In the L.A. area, there could be 1 to 2 inches of rain on the coast and in the valleys. [See **Storm**, A10]

GOP exults before vote in House

A deal to end the shutdown would cede Democrats no ground on healthcare credits.

By MICHAEL WILNER AND ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — President Trump and Republican lawmakers took a victory lap on Tuesday after securing bipartisan support to reopen the government, ending the longest shutdown in U.S. history without ceding ground to any core Democratic demands.

House members were converging on Washington for a final vote expected as early as Wednesday, after 60 senators — including seven Democrats and an independent — advanced the measure on Monday night. Most Democratic lawmakers in the House are expected to oppose the continuing resolution, which does not include an extension of Affordable Care Act tax credits that had been a central demand during the shutdown negotiations.

The result, according to independent analysts, is that premiums will more than double on average for more than 20 million Americans who use the healthcare marketplace, rising from an average of \$888 to \$1,904 for out-of-pocket payments annually, according to KFF.

Democrats in the Senate who voted to reopen the government said they had secured a promise from Senate Majority Leader John Thune, a Republican from South Dakota, that they would get a vote on extending the tax credits next month.

But the vote is likely to fall down party lines. And even if it earned some Republican support, House Speaker Mike Johnson, a Republican from Louisiana, has made no promises he would give the measure a vote in the lower chamber.

An end to the shutdown comes at a crucial time for the U.S. aviation industry ahead of one of the busiest travel seasons around the Thanksgiving holiday. The prolonged closure of the federal government led federal employees in the sector to call out sick in large numbers, prompting an unprecedented directive from the [See **Shutdown**, A7]